Who Leaves Teaching, and Why?

Teacher Attrition in the United States, 2015–2024

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Abstract

Every March, the Current Population Survey asks each American what their longest job was last year and what they are doing this week. For teachers, the distance between the two answers is the cleanest public measure of leaving the profession, and this paper uses it to characterize teacher attrition over 2015–2024: 8.3 percent of college-graduate K–12 teachers leave teaching in a typical year. The composition of that number, not its size, is the story. Almost two thirds of leavers do not move to another job at all: 5.1 of the 8.3 points are exits from the labor force, concentrated at retirement ages, and only 2.1 points are teachers employed in a different occupation a year later—one fifth of them still inside education. Attrition is U-shaped in age, twice as high in private as in public schools (11.6 versus 6.8 percent), and its strongest observable predictors are the shape of the job rather than the person holding it: teaching part of the year or part-time, and lacking a pension plan, move the probability of leaving far more than any demographic trait. The rate spiked with Covid—above 10 percent measured in March 2020—and returned to its pre-pandemic level within two years. Measured identically, teachers leave at the same rate as nurses (8.0 percent), well below social workers (13.6), and slightly above accountants (6.3): teaching is not, in this dimension, an anomalous profession. An appendix validates the retrospective instrument person-by-person against a linked monthly panel built from twenty years of raw CPS files—where both instruments observe the same teacher, they agree on staying or leaving 99 percent of the time—and a second appendix replicates Harris and Adams (2007) on the modern decade.

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1. Introduction

Teachers are the main school input in the production of student achievement (Rivkin, Hanushek and Kain, 2005; Chetty, Friedman and Rockoff, 2014), and replacing one is costly and disruptive for the students left behind (Ingersoll, 2001; Ronfeldt, Loeb and Wyckoff, 2013). Which teachers leave, and why, is therefore a first-order question for education policy, and one on which the public debate runs well ahead of the public data. Claims of a national exodus from the classroom coexist with federal statistics showing single-digit attrition, and the distance between the two is rarely traced back to what it usually is: different instruments answering different questions.

This paper answers three questions on a single, transparent instrument. How many teachers leave the profession in a year? Where do they go? And what distinguishes, observably, the teacher who leaves from the teacher who stays? The instrument is the retrospective measure of the March Current Population Survey (the ASEC supplement), introduced to this literature by Harris and Adams (2007): a person taught last year if the occupation of their longest job last year was a K–12 teaching occupation, and left the profession if they are no longer teaching in the survey week—whether employed in another occupation, unemployed, or out of the labor force. Pooling the ten supplements of 2016–2025 yields 28,932 teacher-year observations covering calendar years 2015 to 2024, a window that brackets the pandemic.

The choice of instrument is not innocent, and it is the methodological contribution of this paper to make it accountable. The CPS offers a second, apparently richer design: its rotation scheme re-interviews the same address twelve months apart, so one can link individual teachers across interviews and watch them leave in something close to real time. We built that panel from the raw monthly files—twenty entry cohorts, 2005–2024—and used it to audit the retrospective measure person by person, for the subsample whose interviews straddle a March supplement. The audit (Appendix A) is reassuring and instructive in equal measure. Wherever both instruments agree that a person was a stable teacher, they agree on whether she stayed or left 99.1 percent of the time. But the linked panel, taken at face value, doubles the attrition rate, and the audit shows exactly why: occupation snapshots from a single reference week misclassify summer months as exits, count temporary absences as leaving, and—most of all—label as "teachers" people whose dominant activity that year was something else. The retrospective anchor, one question about the whole of last year, is immune to all three. What looks like the cruder instrument is in fact the cleaner one, and we can now say so with evidence rather than convention.

Three findings organize the results. First, the level: 8.3 percent of teachers leave the profession per year, a rate stable across two decades of comparison (Harris and Adams measured 7.7 percent in 1992–2001 with the identical design; Appendix B), disturbed only briefly by Covid. Second, the composition: leaving teaching is mostly not a career switch. Exits from the labor force—retirement above all—account for five of the eight points; moves into other jobs account for two, and a fifth of those stay inside education. The marginal leaver is not a teacher lured away by industry; she is a teacher at the end of her career, or one loosely attached to the job to begin with. Third, the predictors: the strongest observable correlates of leaving are working part of the year, working part-time, and lacking a pension plan—features of the match between teacher and job—while demographics move the probability by a point or less. Teaching's attrition is unremarkable among comparable professions; its retirement channel is not.

The rest of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 describes the data and definitions. Section 3 establishes the level and its evolution. Section 4 follows the leavers to their destinations. Section 5 profiles who leaves and estimates the attrition model. Section 6 places teaching among the professions. Section 7 concludes. Appendix A contains the instrument validation, Appendix B the replication of Harris and

Adams on the modern decade, and Appendix C additional estimation output.

2. Data and definitions

The data are the public-use person files of the CPS Annual Social and Economic Supplement (ASEC), downloaded from the Census Bureau for survey years 2016–2025: comma-separated files from 2019 onward, fixed-width files parsed against each year's data dictionary before that. The ASEC asks every adult two questions that bracket a twelve-month window: the occupation of the longest job held during the previous calendar year (`OCCUP`), and the labor-force status and occupation of the current survey week (`A_LFSR`, `PEIOOCC`). The survey year therefore measures attrition for the preceding calendar year; the ten supplements cover 2015–2024.

A person is a **teacher** in year t if the occupation of her longest job in t is a K–12 classroom teaching occupation: preschool and kindergarten, elementary and middle school, secondary school, special education, or teachers not elsewhere classified (census codes 2300–2330 plus 2340 under the 2010 classification, 2360 under the 2018 classification; the core codes are identical across both). Postsecondary teachers and teaching assistants are excluded, following Harris and Adams (2007), and the sample is restricted to college graduates and adults. She is a **leaver** if, in the March interview of year $t+1$, she is no longer teaching: employed in a different occupation, unemployed, or out of the labor force. Employment status comes from the labor-force recode, not from the occupation field, because the unemployed carry their last job's occupation—a detail that matters, since ignoring it counts displaced teachers as stayers. The measure captures leavers only: a teacher who changes school or district remains a teacher here, so these rates are not comparable to "total turnover" figures that add movers and leavers (Ingersoll, 2001; Tan et al., 2024). All statistics use the ASEC supplement weights.

Two limitations are inherited from the instrument. The occupation of the longest job is reported retrospectively, often by another household member, so within-year spells shorter than the longest job are invisible; and the March week is a single snapshot of the destination. Appendix A quantifies both against a linked panel and shows they are second-order for the questions asked here.

3. How many leave

Pooling the decade, **8.25 percent** of teachers leave the profession in a year. The series is flat to gently falling before the pandemic (7.3–8.7 percent), spikes to **10.2 percent** for calendar 2019—measured in the March 2020 interviews, the first Covid weeks—remains elevated at 9.0 for 2020, and is back inside its pre-pandemic range by 2021 (7.1) and stays there through 2024 (7.7). Whatever the pandemic did to teachers' attachment, in this data it was a two-year disturbance, not a regime change; the same conclusion reached by Aldeman and Yi (2025) on the same survey.

The public–private split is large and stable: **6.8 percent** of public-school teachers leave per year against **11.6 percent** of private-school teachers, the same two-to-one ratio the NCES Teacher Follow-up Survey shows in administrative data (7.9 versus 11.7 percent for 2020–21). Men leave slightly more than women (9.1 versus 8.0 percent).

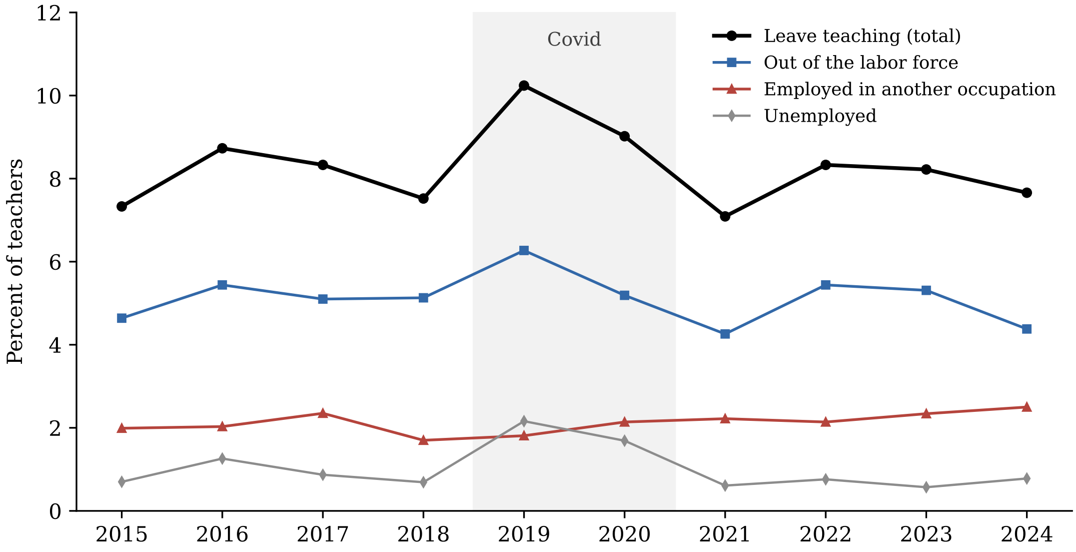

Figure 1: Teacher attrition and its components, 2015–2024.

Share of college-graduate K–12 teachers (longest job of the calendar year) no longer teaching in the following March, by destination. CPS ASEC 2016–2025, supplement weights. The shaded band marks the pandemic surveys: calendar 2019 is measured in March 2020.

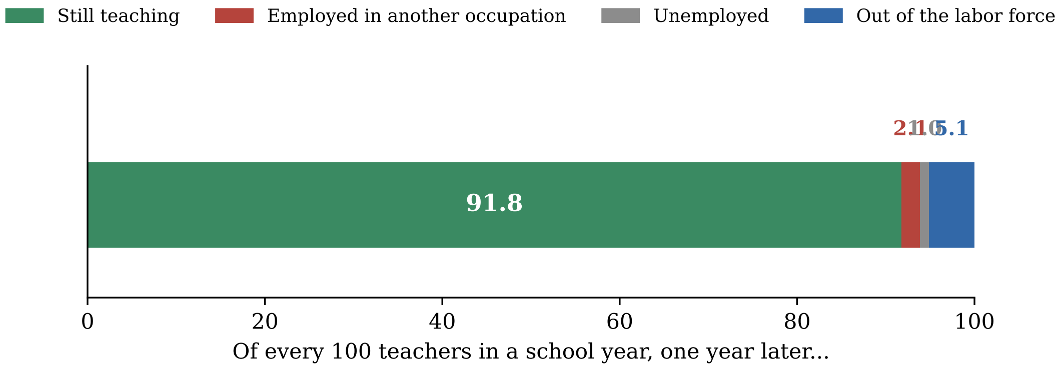

Figure 2: Of every 100 teachers, one year later.

Pooled 2015–2024. Destinations of the 8.25 leavers per 100 teachers: employed in another occupation, unemployed (looking or on layoff), or out of the labor force in the March survey week.

4. Where they go

The composition of attrition is its most misunderstood feature. Of every 100 teachers in a school year, about 92 are teaching a year later. Of the eight who are not, **five are out of the labor force**, one is unemployed, and only **two are working in a different occupation**. The image of attrition as a career switch—the teacher recruited away by a better-paying industry—describes roughly a quarter of it. The dominant channel is the exit from work itself, and Section 5 shows it is concentrated exactly where retirement lives.

Among the minority who do switch, the destinations are strikingly close to the classroom. The single largest detailed destinations are general management, postsecondary teaching, and education administration; tutors, teaching assistants, and childcare workers follow. One in five switchers never leaves educa-

Table 1: Destination occupations of teachers who switch jobs.

Destination occupation	Share of switchers
Managers, all other	6.0%
Postsecondary teachers	4.9%
Education and childcare administrators	4.2%
Lawyers	3.7%
Postsecondary teachers	3.6%
Tutors	2.6%
Teaching assistants	2.6%
Teaching assistants	2.3%
Childcare workers	2.3%
Customer service representatives	2.1%
Secretaries and administrative assistants, except legal, medical, and executive	1.7%
Retail salespersons	1.3%

Share of switchers (leavers employed in another occupation at $t+1$) by detailed destination occupation, pooled 2015–2024, weighted. In total, 19.5 percent of switchers remain in education occupations (census codes 2200–2555).

Table 2: Teachers who stay versus teachers who leave.

	Stayers	Leavers	Difference
Age, years	43.9	50.1	6.2
Female	76.2%	73.4%	-2.8%
Black	9.5%	10.8%	1.3%
Married	67.1%	63.7%	-3.3%
Separated or divorced	10.2%	11.7%	1.5%
Master's degree or higher	52.4%	45.8%	-6.6%
Public school	71.3%	58.0%	-13.3%
Enrolled in a pension plan	68.0%	51.2%	-16.8%
Part-time (<35 h/week)	11.9%	41.4%	29.5%
Worked full year (50+ weeks)	75.6%	31.3%	-44.3%
Weekly earnings ($)	1177.4	1075.0	-102.4

Weighted means over pooled 2015–2024. Characteristics are measured in the teaching year (the longest-job year), not at the destination: earnings are annual wage and salary divided by weeks worked, part-time refers to usual weekly hours, and the pension row is enrollment in an employer plan at the longest job.

tion occupations at all—the move is often a reshuffling within the sector (teacher to administrator, teacher to college instructor) rather than an exit from it. The genuinely out-of-field destinations that remain—customer service, administrative support, retail—are not an upgrade in observable terms, consistent with the evidence that former teachers rarely out-earn their classroom selves (Brummet et al., 2025).

5. Who leaves, and why

The profile of the leaver, measured while she was still teaching, is sharp. Leavers are six years older than stayers (50 versus 44), more often in private schools (42 versus 29 percent), less often covered by a pension plan (51 versus 68 percent), and—above all—far more loosely attached to the job: 41 percent of leavers taught part-time against 12 percent of stayers, and only 31 percent of leavers worked a full 50-week year against 76 percent of stayers. Demographic differences are small by comparison. The teacher

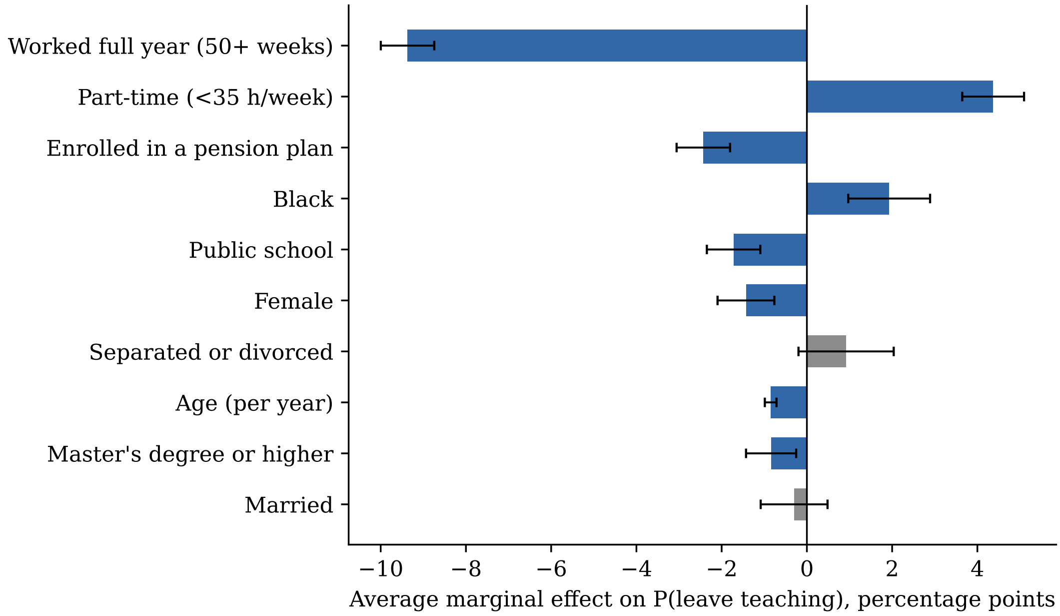

Figure 3: What predicts leaving: average marginal effects.

Probit of leaving on characteristics of the teaching year, with survey-year fixed effects, pooled 2015–2024 (n = 28,328). Bars are average marginal effects in percentage points; whiskers are 95 percent confidence intervals (robust); gray bars are not significant at 5 percent. Age enters with a quadratic; the age profile is shown in Figure 4.

who leaves is not a distinct kind of person; she is a teacher in a distinct kind of job-year.

The multivariate picture confirms it. Holding everything else fixed, having worked a full year is associated with a **9.4 percentage point lower** probability of leaving—by far the largest effect in the model—and part-time work adds **4.4 points** of exit risk on top of the hours themselves. Pension enrollment is associated with 2.4 points less exit, echoing at modern magnitudes the job-lock that Harris and Adams (2007) documented for the 1990s; public-school employment with 1.7 points less. Demographics are an order of magnitude smaller: women leave 1.4 points less than men, Black teachers 1.9 points more, and a master's degree subtracts less than a point. Age is U-shaped—attrition falls to a minimum around the mid-forties (4.3 percent for ages 46–55) and then climbs steeply, to 12.2 percent at 56–64 and 28 percent past 65, almost entirely through the labor-force exit channel: among teachers aged 56–64 who leave, more than three quarters leave employment altogether. Retirement, not disaffection, governs the right side of the curve, as Grissmer and Kirby (1997) argued long before this window.

6. Teaching among the professions

Is 8 percent a lot? The only honest benchmark is other professions measured with the same ruler. Teachers leave teaching at almost exactly the rate nurses leave nursing (8.25 versus 7.99 percent), well below social workers (13.55) and somewhat above accountants (6.30). The ordering is the one Harris and Adams found a generation earlier, with two quiet drifts: nursing's attrition has risen toward teaching's, and accounting's has fallen below both. In a linear probability model with demographic and job controls, the teacher–nurse gap is at most two points in either direction, while social workers exit five to six points more than observably similar teachers (Appendix C). Teaching also keeps its distinctive signature: a larger share of its attrition flows out of the labor force (62 percent, versus 44 for nurses and 21 for social workers), and

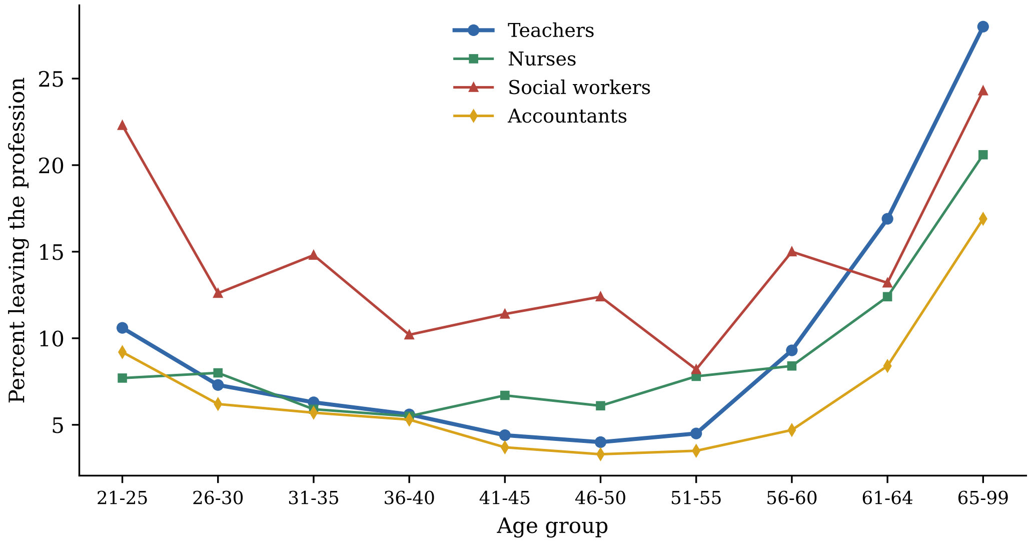

Figure 4: Attrition by age, teaching and comparison professions.

Share leaving the profession per year by age group, pooled 2015–2024, weighted. College graduates in each profession, defined by the longest job of the calendar year.

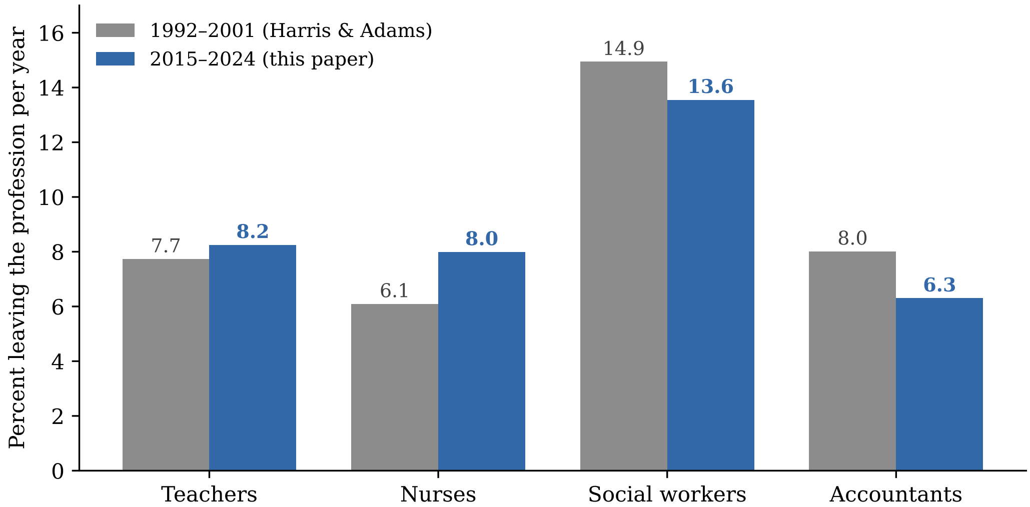

Figure 5: Leaving the profession, then and now.

Annual profession-leaving rates under the identical instrument: Harris and Adams (2007), March CPS 1992–2001, versus this paper, March CPS 2016–2025. College graduates; registered and licensed practical nurses; social workers; accountants and auditors.

the pension coefficient is two to three times larger for teachers than for any comparison profession—the fingerprints of a profession whose exit is organized around retirement systems rather than around outside offers.

7. What it means for policy

Three conclusions follow directly from the anatomy of the 8.25 percent. First, the aggregate level is not the crisis variable; it has been stable for thirty years under the same instrument and sits exactly at the nurse benchmark. Policy aimed at “teacher attrition” in the aggregate is aiming at a number that is neither high by professional standards nor rising. Second, the composition points the lever at attachment, not persuasion: the excess exits sit in part-year and part-time teaching spells, in uncovered (disproportionately private) jobs, and at retirement ages. Converting part-year attachments into full-year contracts, and extending pension coverage where it is thin, target the observable margins that carry the risk; generic retention campaigns do not. Third, the retirement channel is the elephant: five of the eight points never pass through another employer, and their timing is a function of pension design—the margin Podgursky (2003) and the pension literature have long flagged. A policymaker worried about losing experienced teachers should read this as a schedule of predictable, plannable exits, not as a flight from the profession.

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Appendix A. Validating the instrument person by person

The claim that the retrospective measure is the right instrument is tested here at the individual level, using the CPS's own rotation design. A household entering the sample is interviewed in four consecutive months, rests for eight, and is interviewed in the same four calendar months a year later; persons are linked across the eight interviews by household and line identifiers, validated on sex and age progression (Madrian and Lefgren, 2000). From the raw monthly files 2005–2025 we built the twenty entry cohorts of 2005–2024 and kept the unambiguous teachers: employed in a K–12 teaching occupation in *all four* initial interviews. A panel-leaver is one who teaches in *none* of the four follow-up interviews a year later.

For the subsample whose initial window includes March, the same person also answered the retrospective questions of the following year's ASEC, and the two instruments can be cross-tabulated person by person (identifiers link the monthly and supplement files directly). Twenty cohorts give 9,461 such teachers.

Table 3: Panel classification versus March retrospective, cohorts 2005–2024.

	March retrospective classification			
Linked-panel classification	Not a teacher	Stayed	Left	Total
Stayer (teaches all 4 post months)	198	7,911	67	8,176
Leaver (teaches in none)	1,018	10	257	1,285
Total	1,216	7,921	324	9,461

Stable teachers (teaching in all four initial monthly interviews) whose window includes March, observed in all four follow-up interviews and linked to the following ASEC. "Not a teacher": the retrospective reports the longest job of the base year outside K–12 teaching.

Where both instruments regard the person as a base-year teacher, they almost never disagree: 99.1 percent agreement on stay-versus-leave, 77 true disagreements in 9,461 cases, stable at 98–100 percent in every one of the twenty cohorts. The disagreement lives in the 13 percent whom the retrospective does not count as teachers at all. They are not random: 84 percent of them are panel-leavers, and their retrospective longest jobs concentrate in teaching assistant, "other teachers and instructors," education administration, postsecondary teaching, and childcare. In other words, the linked panel's higher attrition (13.6 percent among these stable teachers, against 3.9 under the retrospective) is not evidence of hidden exits; it is the sum of within-education reshuffling and short spells that the anchor question "longest job last year" correctly refuses to count as leaving the profession, plus the reference-week noise—summer non-employment, temporary absences—that a single-week snapshot cannot avoid. The two instruments measure leaving the *classroom this week* and leaving the *profession this year*; for the questions of this paper the second is the estimand, and it is measured consistently.

Appendix B. Harris and Adams (2007), replicated on 2015–2024

Applying Harris and Adams's design verbatim to the modern decade—their teacher definition, their college-graduate restriction, their three comparison professions, their decomposition—yields the following update of their Tables 1–2.

The levels and the ordering have barely moved in a quarter century: teaching's attrition is within half a point of its 1990s value, still statistically indistinguishable from nursing once composition is con-

Table 4: Leaving the profession, by type: 1992–2001 versus 2015–2024.

	Harris & Adams, 1992–2001				This paper, 2015–2024			
	All	Switch	Unemp.	Out LF	All	Switch	Unemp.	Out LF
Teachers	7.73	2.59	0.61	4.53	8.25	2.12	1.00	5.12
Nurses	6.09	1.68	0.86	3.54	7.99	3.66	0.81	3.53
Social workers	14.94	10.87	1.34	2.73	13.55	9.45	1.22	2.89
Accountants	8.01	4.10	1.55	2.36	6.30	1.79	1.18	3.32

Annual rates in percent, college graduates, March CPS. 1992–2001 from Harris and Adams (2007), Tables 1–2; 2015–2024 computed here on ASEC 2016–2025. "Switch": employed in another occupation; "Out LF": out of the labor force in the survey week.

trolled, still five points below social work. The internal composition drifted in interpretable ways—unemployment exits rose (0.6 to 1.0) and the labor-force channel remains teaching's signature, 59 percent of all exits then, 62 percent now. The regression counterparts (Appendix C) tell the same story, including the outsized teacher pension coefficient (-3.6 percentage points, two to three times any comparison profession). Public-school teachers leave at 6.8 percent against their 6.6 in the 1990s. A literature that has spent two decades arguing about whether teacher attrition is exceptional can, on this evidence, close the question: it was not then, and it is not now.

Appendix C. Additional estimation output

Table 5: Annual attrition series with destination decomposition.

Year	Leave teaching	Other occupation	Unemployed	Out of LF	Teachers
2015	7.3%	2.0%	0.7%	4.6%	3,275
2016	8.7%	2.0%	1.3%	5.4%	3,296
2017	8.3%	2.4%	0.9%	5.1%	3,294
2018	7.5%	1.7%	0.7%	5.1%	3,266
2019	10.2%	1.8%	2.2%	6.3%	2,854
2020	9.0%	2.1%	1.7%	5.2%	2,777
2021	7.1%	2.2%	0.6%	4.3%	2,618
2022	8.3%	2.1%	0.8%	5.4%	2,609
2023	8.2%	2.3%	0.6%	5.3%	2,511
2024	7.7%	2.5%	0.8%	4.4%	2,432

Calendar years; survey year is calendar plus one. Weighted; unweighted teacher counts in the last column.

Table 6: Teacher coefficient against each comparison profession (LPM).

	Nurses	Social workers	Accountants
No controls	0.26 (0.34)	−5.30 (0.74)	1.95 (0.40)
+ demographics	−0.08 (0.36)	−5.40 (0.74)	2.86 (0.42)
+ job characteristics	−1.83 (0.39)	−5.47 (0.75)	1.19 (0.45)

Coefficient (percentage points) on a teacher dummy in a weighted linear probability model of leaving the profession, pooled 2015–2024 with survey-year fixed effects; robust standard errors in parentheses. Demographics: age, age^2, female, Black, married, separated/divorced, advanced degree. Job characteristics: log weekly earnings, pension enrollment. Mirrors Harris and Adams (2007), Table 3.